PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Freedmen's Bureau — A House Divided

Success, Failure, or Both?

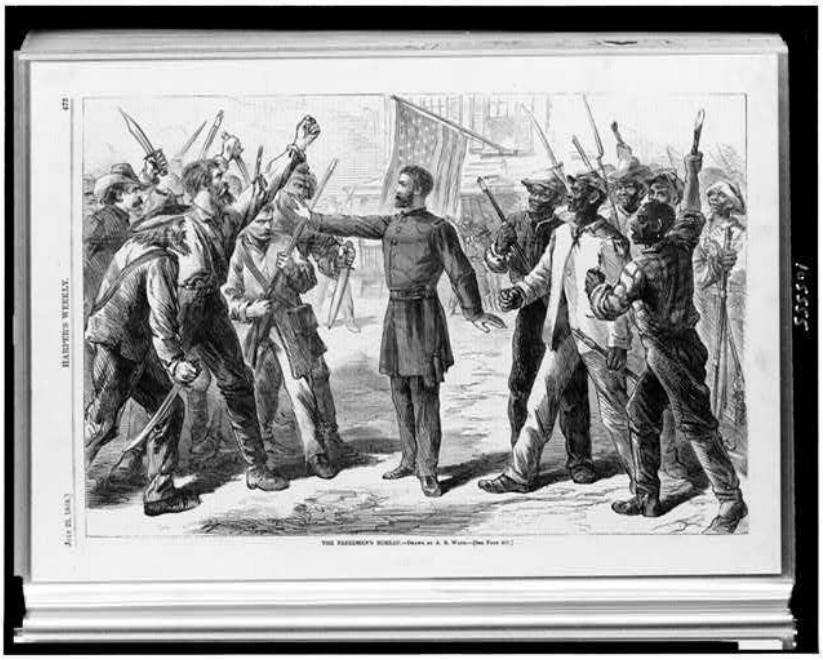
Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Freedmen's Bureau — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. A fair judgment weighs both sides. Sort the evidence, then decide how to grade the Bureau

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1868 — "The Freedmen's Bureau"



"The Freedmen's Bureau" — wood engraving by Alfred R. Waud, Harper's Weekly, 1868, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · THE BUREAU'S RECORD — Achievements and limits

> *Achievements: millions of food rations; ~4,000 schools; foundations of Black colleges; labor contracts enforced; families reunited; marriages legalized.*
> *Limits: chronically underfunded and understaffed; fierce white resistance and violence; the promise of land mostly broken; shut down by 1872.*
> *— summarized from the historical record. Public domain*

— summarized from the historical record. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · TWO COLUMNS

From the source, list two clear successes of the Freedmen's Bureau and two clear limits or failures.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE BIGGEST FAILURE

Many historians call the failure to give freedpeople land the Bureau's most damaging shortcoming. Why would land have mattered so much?

- ☐ A. land was worthless after the war
- ☐ B. land meant independence; without it, freedpeople had to work for their former enslavers
- ☐ C. freedpeople did not want land
- ☐ D. land had nothing to do with freedom

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · READ THE TEACHER

Using the teacher's quote, explain what the Bureau's schools meant to freedpeople. Why would families “starve themselves” to send children to school?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · YOUR VERDICT

Given its impossible task and limited support, was the Freedmen's Bureau a success, a failure, or both? Defend your verdict in three or four sentences, using evidence.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Freedmen's Bureau — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Successes: 1)... 2)... | Limits: 1)... 2)..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. land meant independence; without it, freedpeople had to work for their former enslavers**

Right. Land meant economic independence. Without it, most freedpeople had to work for their former enslavers — which is exactly how sharecropping trapped them in poverty and dependence.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Education meant... so families were willing to..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I would judge the Bureau as ___ because..."